Satisfied, Akbar waited in Lucknow for his army to catch up, then marched on to Jaunpur. Here, Asaf Khan re-enters the story. It was a splashy entrance.

Newly enriched with Gond wealth, little of which had made it to Akbar's treasury, Asaf Khan brought tributes for the padishah, along with 5000 cavalry freshly bought with the gold of Chauragarh. The padishah was pleased; some days later, in mid-July 1565, he sent Asaf Khan and his prime troops in pursuit of the Uzbeks. But only two months afterwards, in September, Asaf Khan abandoned his mission and took flight himself; and in the late spring of 1566, he joined Ali Quli's rebellion.

Asaf Khan's desertion did not share the communal logic of the Uzbek uprising – he was Tajik, not Uzbek – but it does illustrate something of the layers of suspicion, resentment and ambition that animated the feuds between Akbar's nobility at this time; and reveal how fear – of an increasingly powerful padishah and the decreasing autonomy of his chiefs in their fiefs – might tip a man out of the fold.

At the heart of it, of course, is that Asaf Khan had gained a vast booty and sent nothing of it to court, hoping to protect himself by bribing the palace accountants. These men began to mutter about his 'former unwillingness to hand over the spoils', and suggest that even now he had retained more than he had revealed.[41] It may also be the case, as both Nizamuddin and Badauni suggest, that it was Akbar's new vizier, a stickler called Muzaffar Khan, who threatened to charge Asaf Khan with financial fraud; at which the covetous commander, his heart full of 'suspicion and anxiety',[42] ran away.

Muzaffar Khan was one of Bairam Khan's men, parsimonious and outspoken, but talented enough to have attracted Akbar's attention and favour. He worked with another of Akbar's new recruits, Todar Mal – both men charged with supervising the chieftains' revenue and ensuring that an adequate share of it came to the imperial treasury. This did not endear the two men to the chiefs; the indignant fief-holders couldn't decide which one of them they hated more. Badauni quotes 'a certain wit' who put the dilemma in verse: 'A dog of a Raja is better than Muzaffar Khan / Although a dog is a hundred times better than a Raja.'[43]

Munim Khan, Akbar's old ataliq and current khan-khanan, had more reason than most to despise Muzaffar Khan – an accountant who had once